# CGIAR Innovation Readiness Level Guidelines

**October 2024**

### How to assess innovation readiness

**Please use the [Innovation Readiness Calculator] to help determine the correct readiness level** that you can support with evidence for QA approval. The calculator assists in identifying a level that aligns with the available evidence. We have found that readiness levels determined using the calculator are better aligned with the supporting evidence provided.

The readiness level assessed by QA will be based solely on the evidence you have submitted. Therefore, please ensure you provide the best available evidence for the level you select. While an innovation might theoretically have a higher readiness level, the QA review will only consider the evidence provided, with no additional research conducted to corroborate your chosen readiness level.

Note that at output level, a single readiness score is given for the innovation, irrespective of the specific geo-location where the innovation is being designed, tested and/or scaled. Geo-location-specific scoring is done at outcome level, as part of innovation packaging and scaling readiness assessments.

### Level definitions

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| **Level 9** | The innovation is validated for its ability to achieve a specific impact under uncontrolled conditions. |
| **Level 8** | The innovation is being tested for its ability to achieve a specific impact under uncontrolled conditions. |
| **Level 7** | The innovation is validated for its ability to achieve a specific impact under semi-controlled conditions. |
| **Level 6** | The innovation is being tested for its ability to achieve a specific impact under semi-controlled conditions. |
| **Level 5** | The innovation is validated for its ability to achieve a specific impact under fully controlled conditions. |
| **Level 4** | The innovation is being tested for its ability to achieve a specific impact under fully controlled conditions. |
| **Level 3** | The innovation’s key concepts have been validated for their ability to achieve a specific impact. |

**Level 2** The innovation's key concepts are being formulated or designed.

**Level 1** The innovation's basic principles are being researched for their ability to achieve a specific impact.

**Level 0** The innovation is at idea stage.

## Further clarifications on scoring

Levels 4, 6, and 8 represent **testing stages**, where the innovation is actively evaluated for its ability to achieve specific impacts under varying conditions:

- **Level 4** involves testing in a fully controlled environment,
- **Level 6** in semi-controlled conditions, and
- **Level 8** in uncontrolled, real-world settings.

For these testing levels, the appropriate evidence should include data and documentation from the ongoing trials or studies that will demonstrate the innovation's performance under the specified conditions:

- **Level 4** requires controlled environment testing evidence, such as lab reports or experimental data.
- **Level 6** needs evidence from semi-controlled conditions, like pilot study results where not all variables are regulated.
- **Level 8** calls for field trial data or initial user feedback to demonstrate performance in real-world settings.

In contrast, levels 5, 7, and 9 are **validation stages**, where evidence from prior testing is used to confirm that the innovation can achieve the desired impact under specific conditions:

- **Level 5** confirms readiness based on results from fully controlled tests,
- **Level 7** validates readiness in semi-controlled environments, and
- **Level 9** establishes readiness in uncontrolled, real-world contexts, with limited or no involvement of CGIAR.

For these validation levels, evidence should ~~provide~~ conclusive reports that the innovation has successfully met impact criteria based on previous testing:

- **Level 5** requires a validation report that confirms performance in a controlled environment.
- **Level 7** needs documentation, like a summary of pilot results, showing validation in semi-controlled settings.
- **Level 9** requires evidence of validation in real-world conditions with limited or no involvement of CGIAR, such as field data.

In summary, testing levels require evidence of active evaluation under specific conditions, while validation levels require confirmation that testing results prove the innovation’s readiness for impact.